Check for updates

Article

Hai Gui or Hai Dai? Chinese Student Migrants and the Role of Norwegian Mobility Capital in Career Success

YOUNG
25(2) 174–189
© 2017 SAGE Publications and
YOUNG Editorial Group
SAGE Publications
sagepub.in/home.nav
DOI: 10.1177/1103308816670821
http://you.sagepub.com

Aihua Hu[1]
David Cairns[2]

Abstract

In this article, we look at an example of student migration between Asia and Europe: movement between China and Norway, with the main objective of illustrating the value of studying in Norway to career development upon return to the sending country. Adapting terminology associated with Bourdieu, we discuss this experience as 'mobility capital', exploring the value of skills and capacities acquired while abroad in career success. Evidence is drawn from a recent qualitative study of former student migrants from across China, all of whom had previously studied in Norway at Master's degree level. Analysis of our material demonstrates the strengths and weaknesses of what we term Norwegian 'mobility capital', with discussion of these outcomes organized using two heuristic categories: 'Hai Gui', a term that refers to a returnee experiencing career success, and 'Hai Dai', which relates to returnees who cannot find a secure job upon return.

Keywords

China, Norway, students, migration, mobility, Bourdieu

[1] Department of Education Studies, Hong Kong Baptist University, Kowloon Tong, Hong Kong.
[2] Centre for Research and Studies in Sociology, ISCTE-University of Lisbon, Edifício ISCTE, Av. das Forças Armadas, Lisboa, Portugal.

Corresponding author:
Aihua Hu, Department of Education Studies, Hong Kong Baptist University, Rm AAB 844, 8/F, Academic and Administrative Building, University Road, Hong Kong Baptist University, Kowloon Tong, Hong Kong.
E-mail: huaihuald@hotmail.com

Introduction

The experience of studying in a foreign country represents a means for learners to enhance their future career prospects, whether this be in terms of finding a job in the host nation or improving their occupational chances upon their return to the sending society. The basic idea is that skills and capacities acquired while abroad can equip a student migrant to better compete in the labour market, having accrued an advantage their sedentary peers lack; the most obvious example being foreign language fluency in relation to jobs with an international dimension. However, the experience of living in another country may also lead to the emergence of a broad range of intercultural competences that may have a more indirect but no less important bearing on professional development, such as having a better understanding of how to relate to foreign consumers in a business environment or learning about different ways to approach challenges in the workplace.

In sociological terms, we can view this process as an example of how 'academic capital' acquired in a foreign university acts as a means of strengthening one's position in a domestic job market (Bourdieu, 1984, 1986); what is sometimes referred to as 'mobility capital' (see, e.g., Murphy-Lejeune, 2002). But while this may be a valuable resource, we cannot assume that studying abroad automatically leads to career success. While the possibility exists that employers will value skills and capacities acquired abroad, it may also be the case that these new attributes lack clear application and therefore fail to make a difference to job chances on return. Taking into account these considerations, in this article, we will try to demonstrate the value and some of the limitations of skills acquired during student migration, focusing upon the example of circulation between China and Norway.

In doing so, we will be utilizing two heuristic categories that demonstrate the strengths and weaknesses of Norwegian mobility capital: 'Hai Gui', a term that literally means sea turtle but is colloquially used in China to refer to an overseas returnee experiencing career success, and 'Hai Dai', which translates into English as seaweed but also refers to returnees who cannot find a secure job upon return (see Hao and Welsh, 2013; Louie, 2006).[1] In what follows, we provide an outline of our main research question and research context, followed by a presentation of the main findings from our fieldwork and discussion of how these perspectives help inform our understanding of the value of student migration to career success.

The Question of Student Migration

In conducting this analysis, we acknowledge that we are taking part in an existing debate on student migration and other forms of tertiary education level circulation. This research topic has become very popular among academics from across the social sciences. Prominent themes including assessing the value of short duration exchanges between universities as part of platforms such as the European Commission's Erasmus programme (Feyen and Krzaklewska, 2013), elaborating upon the relationship between international experience and graduate employability (Crossman and Clarke, 2010), exploring the relationship between gender and academic migration (Jöns, 2011) and charting the effect of the expansion of student mobility systems upon third-level educational institutions (Brooks and Waters, 2011). The scale of development in this

field can be gauged from the fact that a UK-based literature review on what is sometimes more formally referred to as 'International Student Mobility' by King et al. (2010) found in the region of 100 relevant studies published in the English language. And the volume of work available has grown exponentially since this time. However, these studies for the most part offer perspectives on student circulation within Europe and North America, albeit with some inclusion of some movers from other global regions including Southeast Asia (e.g., Waters, 2005).

Putting our work into a theoretical framework, we need to ask questions about the value of student migration; for example, how is it that 2 or 3 years spent at a Norwegian university can have a lasting impact upon career progress on return to China? The answer we will posit relates to the idea of 'mobility capital'. In our research context, this can take the form of academic capital comprising internationally recognized credentials alongside less readily quantifiable skills and capacities. In practice, this latter faculty may involve accepting different modes of thinking about work or new ways of socially relating to other people, not entirely dissimilar to the philosophy that underlines intra-European institutional mobility programmes such as Erasmus, which makes explicit reference to intercultural understanding albeit more in relation to civic-mindedness and performing a de facto ambassadorial function for the European institutions than in terms of personal development (see, e.g., European Commission, 2014). But in our case, it may be that upon return to China, at least within a workplace wherein there is a high degree of interaction with an international clientele, intercultural competences can be drawn upon that help ensure a business is successful, enabling mobility capital to make a positive contribution to the individual and society.

In taking this approach, we are building upon insights from prior studies of student mobility (see especially Balaz and Williams, 2004; Waters, 2006), and deeper theoretical precedents associated with Pierre Bourdieu in relation to social, economic, cultural and academic capital (see Bourdieu, 1984, 1986). Significantly, mobility capital can be comprised of a dynamic range of these resources: expanded social networks, a higher earning potential, better understandings of other societies and internationally recognized educational credentials acquired while abroad. While enhanced foreign language fluency, in particular of the English language, is also prominent, there is also recognition of the significance learning outside the classroom has upon personal and professional development. The mobility capital generating 'habitus', to borrow another term associated with Bourdieu, is not just the university by also the experience of living abroad. For this reason, the scope of our research questions looks beyond what Bourdieu (1984: 114) terms 'scientific knowledge' and enters the civic sphere of Norwegian society.

Stating the existence of an informal learning process alongside the more formal acquisition of educational credentials during a stay at a foreign university is important, constituting a vital element of understanding the international student migration experience. However, our exploration of this theme does not assume that all those who have studied in Norway successfully mobilize their Norwegian mobility capital on return to China. On the contrary, we hypothesize that while some graduates successfully integrate what they have learnt into their careers on return, others do not, opening-up additional questions regarding why this might be the case. This dichotomy thus explains our use of the colloquial terms 'Hai

Gui' and 'Hai Dai', which in more theoretical terms relate to successful, and perhaps not so successful use of Norwegian mobility capital, respectively. And in our discussion, we will attempt to illustrate these two positions with the use of empirical evidence, thereby making what we hope is an original contribution to the field of student migration.

As well as following this theoretical precedent, we also have an opportunity to contribute to a long-standing debate within Youth Studies on the related issue of education to work transitions, particularly for graduates, and consideration of how social capital and other resources shape career outcomes against a backdrop of structural factors (e.g., Furlong and Cartmel, 1997; Halve and Bynner, 2007). More recent additions to this theoretical tradition also contemplate the value of the more abstract qualities of youth mobility. For example, Cuzzocrea and Mandich (2015) emphasize the imaginative power of mobility in encouraging young people to think more expansively about the future, with acceptance that adopting a more global perspective enables new possibilities in the life course to emerge (see also Leccardi, 2005). Lest we appear too prescriptive, we must also acknowledge that staying home and taking advantage of local opportunities can also be a winning strategy in reaching personal and professional goals (Cuzzocrea and Mandich, 2015; see also O'Connor, 2005), a position that also constitutes a rejection of the neoliberal demand to make oneself available for work at any cost and in any place (Yoon, 2014). Therefore, a foreign study experience can but does not necessarily support transitions to and within the workplace.

We are therefore addressing one of the questions explicit in the Migration Studies approach to student mobility, and more implicit in Youth Studies, concerning the value of foreign study experience to subsequent career development: basically, asking if a move abroad for higher education contributes to later success in the labour market? And by success, we mean finding a better job than would have been possible without spending time abroad or a position commensurate to education and skill level when there is a high level of competition for a small number of jobs. As noted above, our specific focus is upon former Chinese student migrants, now graduates who have entered the labour market, who have previously studied in Norway at Master's degree level. This means that we are in effect assessing the impact of specific acquisitions of postgraduate Norwegian mobility capital when mobilized on return to China, using the 'Hai Gui' and 'Hai Dai' categories as a means of discussing this issue.

Chinese Student Migration to Norway

The China to Norway and back again trajectory is just one small example of the global circulation of tertiary educated young people, the scale of which is considerable. Estimates produced by United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) suggest that there are in the region of 4 million undergraduate and postgraduate level student migrants worldwide (UNESCO, 2016). These figures also provide an indication of the main directions of student migration flows, with Southeast Asia by far the most popular sending region, and North America and Europe the most likely receiving societies (see also Bodycott, 2009;

Ley and Kobayashi, 2005; McBurnie and Ziguras, 2001; Waters, 2005). In more precise terms, the most recently published statistics from the UNESCO (2016) database, collated in 2012, show that China has 712,157 students studying abroad, with the USA (225,474), Japan (96,592) and Australia (87,980) being the most popular destination countries. The United Kingdom was the most popular destination in Europe (81,776), and there were 733 Chinese students registered as studying in Norway.[3]

It should be noted that the practice of student migration does not necessarily conform to the norms of neoclassical migration; student movers do not generally move abroad for reasons of employment or with a view towards more or less permanent settlement. And while return migration is a well-established feature of global circulation, an assumption remains that this tends to happen after a relatively long period of time has elapsed (e.g., Anwar, 1979; Bovenkerk, 1974; Cassarino, 2008). In reality, that a return may be made after a period of a few years, or less, does not mean that a stay abroad lacks significance; on the contrary, a concentrated period of study and discovery in a new country has great potential value when the acquired skills are able to be successfully redeployed in the home labour market (see Cairns, 2014).

In regard to statistical indicators in China, official figures confirm that return is the norm for students, meaning that this is not for the most part an example of brain drain but rather a more circulatory movement (see Guth and Gill, 2008). There do, however, seem to be some differences in the likelihood of return compared to historical precedent. Statistics from the Chinese Ministry of Education (MoE) confirm that around 70 to 80 per cent of overseas students return to China to work (MoE, 2016). However, this figure would have been even higher in the past, when there were relatively few self-financing overseas students moving abroad from China. Most were sent by the government under schemes with the requirement to return to China after their overseas studies were completed, although admittedly not all abided by this stipulation. It is also important to remember that outward migration from China was, until the end of the Cultural Revolution in 1977, restricted to movement to other socialist countries. But with the recent and rapid development of the Chinese economy, increasing numbers of Chinese families have become affluent enough to send their children abroad to be educated. And they do so with a view to them obtaining credentials and a global vision that Chinese universities may not be able to offer, at least not to the same extent.

Looking at our specific educational cohort, while statistical evidence is sparse, figures from EOL (2011) confirm the popularity of studying for a Master's degree abroad. In 2010, about 63 per cent of the Chinese overseas students went abroad for postgraduate study (EOL, 2011). And according to government statistics, 80.7 per cent of the returnees hold Master's degree (MoE, 2016). That this should be the case provides a very strong justification for our choice of educational cohort. However, our student migration question is not concerned with quantifying levels of movement among Chinese students to and from Norway or in replicating the quantitative approaches of other studies have also looked at the 'Hai Gui or Hai Dai' issue (see, e.g., Hao and Welsh, 2013). Rather, as detailed in the preceding section, we are considering the impact the mobility capital accrued during this foreign study experience upon the individual when he or she returns to China through taking an in-depth assessment of this issue among specific cases.

Methodological Approach

While we have a general idea about how many Chinese students are leaving and returning, we know less about the experience of entering and advancing within the labour market in China after a foreign study experience. In order to assess this issue, and the 'Hai Gui or Hai Dai' question, we have conducted research with a group of 17 former Master's degree students. All of these graduates previously studied at the University of Oslo between 2005 and 2009, having undertaken their undergraduate degrees in mainland China. This means that we are studying an example of postgraduate-level student migration and return as opposed to looking at 'credit mobility' exchanges that typically take place within the structure of an undergraduate degree, the form of student 'migration' that forms the main focus for studies in the field of 'International Student Mobility' in Europe (King et al., 2010).

In regard to the present occupational status of these graduates, one works in a private legal company providing bilingual legal services, five work as civil servants, one is an administrator in a foreign language department at a renowned university, two are employed as university lecturers and the remaining eight respondents work in foreign companies, one a Norwegian company and another a Chinese company that cooperates with foreign partners. All live in the major metropolitan cities in China: five in Shanghai, four in Beijing, two in Tianjin, two in Guangzhou, one in Chengdu, one in Guzhou, one in Luoyang and one in Hangzhou. Data were gathered by Aihua Hu using an open-ended questionnaire survey, administered using emails, with the bulk of this work conducted during the latter half of 2015 and early 2016. Follow-up communication was realized through QQ, an internet chat tool similar to Skype but more popular in China. This online approach was a necessity given the impracticality of travelling to all the respondents' locations.

All responses were collated and translated into English by Aihua Hu, with a multilayered thematic approach employed in data analysis following guidelines from Kurdziel and Libarkin (2002). This provided a means of identifying aspects of the study abroad experience that were directly or indirectly related to career development, for example, in finding a job or contributing towards advancement within an organization. Through this means, we can move towards a more coherent idea of the utility of Norwegian mobility capital, identifying the attributes that have significance for the building of a graduate career.

Discussion of Results

Common Challenges

There were a number of common themes prominent in all accounts. For example, all the participants expressed the view that their 2 to 3-year stays in Norway had been an unforgettable experience. Additionally, everyone stated that they had a clear goal for overseas study: to experience a different culture and gain some advantages from this experience in their future professional careers, suggesting that the significance of intercultural skills was recognized alongside the value of a new educational qualification to their job chances. In this sense, we can see that regardless of the eventual

outcome; they were all originally aiming towards a 'Hai Gui' situation rather than undertaking foreign study for purely personal reasons.

Looking at other transversal themes, the biggest challenge mentioned by all participants was language, not so much the issue of communicating in Norwegian but rather studying in English. This situation was attributed to the fact that the student respondents lacked sufficient opportunities to speak English or read academic works in English before they came to Norway. However, this deficit meant that the chance to develop English language skills became one of the main gains from the overseas study experience, and a faculty valued by employers operating in global contexts, thus presenting another example of intercultural competence acquisition. But typically, the respondents mentioned that it took them between a semester and a year to be able to communicate with their classmates and professors with relative ease in English, both orally and in writing.

> Language is my greatest challenge. It took me a semester to overcome this challenge. Besides going to lectures and reading what the professors assigned to us, I never give up learning English every day. In this way, I could keep up with my classmates in the second semester. (Jack)[4]

The other main shared challenge related to coping with being a self-financed student, providing us with a reminder of the importance of economic resources within the practice of migration. The majority of our respondents were not from privileged backgrounds; they might best be described as coming from families with average or slightly above-average household incomes. This situation helps explain why they chose Norway as a destination, as they did not have to pay tuition fees. However, the cost of living in Oslo generally proved to be much higher than anticipated, exceeding the equivalent level of most cities in China. To cope it was necessary to find part-time jobs, which usually meant making recourse to manual or unskilled work. In fact, only one of our respondents, who was from a well-off family, did not do so. It was, however, interesting to observe that this was the first time these students had such jobs, and a positive aspect of this experience was that they learned to better appreciate the challenges entailed in such work and subsequently became more sympathetic towards people who have such positions. This appreciation also extended to their parents, many of whom they now realized had worked exceedingly hard to support them in their jobs to support them in their studies abroad.

One other shared challenge mentioned concerned living independently. Once again, this was largely a first-time experience. Although 11 of the respondents had studied for their undergraduate degrees outside their hometowns, they still had the safety net of friends or relatives nearby, in addition to being able to make regular trips home. None of these scenarios were present in Norway, meaning a greater step outside the comfort zone was required for the first time in their lives. As they explain, they were totally alone in a culture that was very different from their own.

> I didn't understand what the professors were talking about and I had no courage to talk to my classmates. I felt very lonely and helpless. (Lee)

> Being alone in my room, I could even hear the sound of my breath, which drives me crazy. I resorted to watching sitcoms to keep myself stable. (Alice)

All these shared experiences tell us much about the challenge of being a Chinese student migrant in Norway, although many of the issues described will be familiar to readers who have also studied abroad in the past, regardless of their country of origin. We can nevertheless see that commonplace challenges are an integral part of student migration, and that coping with issues such as learning a new language and overcoming social isolation are integral elements of the process of acquiring mobility capital, as much as acquiring new knowledge in the lecture theatre or laboratory.

Shared Benefits

Having considered some of the most prominent shared challenges entailed in studying abroad, we must also acknowledge common benefits. Something that was not necessarily noticed at the time of their stays abroad was the fact that the foreign study experience was helping to make these students more independent. As mentioned above, that they had to step out of their comfort zone was difficult, but the capacity to manage their lives without external help close at hand was a valuable acquisition. All agreed that they became more mature, mentally and psychologically, as a result of this experience despite the initial difficulties.

This experience led to many of them making a concerted effort to win new friends in Norway. As explained below:

> I would go to our common kitchen frequently to meet anyone living in our corridor and I would cook Chinese food and invite them to have dinner with me. I found it was a good way to make friends. Many foreigners like Chinese cuisine. (Fay)

Similar experiences in making friends were recorded, leading to greater success in becoming more convivial on campus and at other social gatherings. A shared finding was that it was easier to make friend with people if they took the initiative, representing the enhancement of one's friendship and acquaintanceship networks, expanding what might be termed 'bridging social capital' (see, e.g., Putnam, 2000) through mobilizing one's own cultural resources, in this case, via Chinese cooking. However, they also mentioned that it was not always easy to make friends with Norwegians. This was not due to the fact that they had negative attitudes towards them; on the contrary, the respondents said that in general Norwegians were friendly and polite, but also quiet and shy people.

Other positive outcomes include the experience of working with professors and fellow students, and of studying in Norway. As Lee explained, they were impressed by how serious the professors were about their work and their openness towards students' ideas and opinions:

> My professors always encouraged us to challenge them and would praise us for bringing new ideas to the class. They gave us the freedom to express ourselves. They never looked down upon our ideas. At first, I felt some of my ideas were quite naïve and not worth bringing out to discuss. But later I knew it was part of the brainstorming process, and the seemingly silliest ideas could later ignite great ideas. (Lee)

This appreciation of openness extended to local government and the philosophy of putting people first, for example:

> The government planned to rebuild the ski jumping platform in Oslo. However, after doing some research and consultation, the City Council of Oslo vetoed the plan. They believed that the old one was still good enough to use and thought it was a waste of taxpayers' money. As a result the platform was not rebuilt. (Jack)

Norwegians' sense of environmental protection also left a deep impression, including the practice of recycling different used materials. Several respondents mentioned seeing Norwegians wash milk or juice carton boxes, dry them, fold them and then put them away in a separate box for recycling. Besides this, there were separate garbage bins for glass, metals, used batteries and other forms of trash. Used plastic water bottles could also be redeemed for cash or supermarket coupons. This appreciation was extended to Norwegians' love of outdoor activities during summer, when people go camping or have a barbecue in the woods. When doing so, they clean up before they leave: if they cannot find a place to throw away the trash, they will take it with them and properly dispose of it afterwards. This was a first-time observation for the students and ultimately led to them acquiring the habit of recycling when in Norway and after they returned to China, representing a possible example of intercultural social learning (Cairns and Growiec, 2011).

One final positive remark concerned the level of trust Norwegians have in each other. Four of the participants mentioned the 'ticket episode' on the subway. As Norwegian readers may be aware, in Oslo, there are neither conductors checking tickets nor electronic devices preventing people from boarding the subway without a ticket. There are instead self-service vending machines, where passengers buy one-way, daily or weekly tickets if they have not already purchased a monthly ticket in the city centre. In addition, there are machines for people to stamp the time on the ticket before boarding. However, there will be random checks to see if anyone boards the train without a ticket by subway staff two or three times a month. The respondents did not know this rule when they first came and did not stamp the time on the ticket before boarding. They happened to be caught by the subway staff and told them that they did not know about the rule and thought it was enough to have a ticket. The staff believed them and rather than fine them, showed them what to do. Later, they learnt that some people would purposely postpone stamping the boarding time on the ticket but staff still usually believed passengers' explanations. This was important since one would not only be fined but also be on record as a dishonest person for a future employment reference should the matter be reported. They thanked the staff for trusting them, and they said it was hard to put how they viewed this in words, but they felt respected as an individual as a result of this typical Norwegian experience.

Gains in Intercultural and Academic Skills

In evaluating the positive aspects of the Norwegian study experience in regard to new intercultural and academic skills instrumental to career success, we cannot dichotomize these students into two neat groups of 'Hai Gui' and 'Hai Dai' respondents due to the dominance of the former scenario over the latter. This is not to say

that this success came easy to all; on the contrary, it generally took respondents some time to find a job that they wanted and liked. But that they eventually were successful, and attributed this success at least in part to various aspects of their recently acquired mobility capital, means we can draw an initial conclusion that the gains from studying in Norway outweighed negative aspects, even taking into account the difficulties of the initial dislocation and acclimatization period.

Stays in Norway were also seen as positive in regard to developing new perspectives on life outside the workplace, in facilitating a process of becoming more mature, mentally and psychologically; in particular, becoming more responsible was regarded as an important acquisition. Development was also perceived in terms of academic abilities, which were significantly boosted by 2 to 3 years of overseas study, reminding us of the continued importance of instrumental skills related to their educational courses. There was also the chance to keep up-to-date with the latest developments in one's academic field and discuss matters with peers, professors and occasionally world-famous experts. One example was in mastering the art of writing research papers.

> I think my study there was the time at which I understand what being an academic means and how to be a real scholar, even though I might not become a scholar in the future. I still got the spirit and ways of doing things. (Annie)

All the students were proud of writing their Master's dissertation in English. One of them even won an extra scholarship for his dissertation, which had a positive impact on his further academic development. Interpersonal skills also greatly improved through working on group projects with fellow students. In doing these collaborations, they learned how to listen to others, properly express their opinions and feelings and negotiate with different classmates, representing another example of bridging social capital. In their part-time jobs, they also learned how to communicate with their superiors and fight for their rights. For example, one respondent and her friend were cheated by the owner of an Italian restaurant, who refused to pay them after they worked there for 2 months. They argued with the owner and told him that they knew their rights and if he did not pay them as promised, they would sue him. Eventually, they received their wages and were very proud of their courage.

Gains and 'Losses' in Career Development

Gains brought by the overseas study experience were noted in a number of related areas. In preparation for job hunting, the respondents credited their ability to engage in career planning to having studied in Norway. They acknowledged that they had formed the habit of making plans well ahead of time and would do some sort of research before making decisions. This involved setting both short-term and long-term goals, a process that made seemingly formidable tasks manageable, reminding us of the previous comments about the imaginative power of mobility (Cuzzocrea and Mandich, 2015). They also understood that an ambitious career dream should be realized incrementally. For example, one of the respondents was determined to work for the good of people and the environment in China. She was first employed by a small non-governmental organization (NGO) with a poor salary, but she said that she knew that with a few years' work experience she could gain access to her dream

workplace. This meant that she did not mind enduring this less ambitious initial phase. And as she predicted, she was eventually employed by the Department of Corporative Responsibility of a large international company, working as a consultant 2 years later, after which she was promoted to the position of senior consultant.

In addition, a number of respondents explained that their overseas experience in Norway in one way or another helped them to get jobs in international organizations or in companies doing business abroad. They attributed success to their language proficiency, interpersonal skills, foreign experiences and the value of an overseas degree, all instrumental outcomes of studying in Norway. For example, in the case of Jack:

> Yes, it [overseas experience] has had a positive impact on my getting the job in a Dutch NGO. When I applied for jobs in international organisations or companies, the bosses commended my skills in communicating with people of foreign backgrounds and my way of dealing with international affairs, and when I applied for a teaching position the leaders thought highly of my English and international experiences. (Jack)

However, alongside the obvious gains, we must also take into account the potential 'losses' due to time spent abroad not paying off to the extent that these graduates would like. Three of the respondents who now work as civil servants said that their overseas experience did not give them advantages in getting their jobs. In China, usually if one wants to become a civil servant, he or she has to take national/regional exams, meaning there is no advantage to be gained from foreign educational credentials.

> I don't think my overseas experiences have helped. The [national/regional] exams have their own theoretical framework. (Wendy)

> According to my personal experience, I don't think that my Norwegian experience has helped me. Whether you can get the job depends on how well you've done in the [national/regional] exams. If you can be in the top three among the examinees, you will have the chance to get the position, of course on condition that you perform well in the interviews. But from what I have experienced, overseas experience indeed is an advantage in getting jobs other than civil servant. (Fay)

In such situations, the impact of studying in Norway was thought to be generally positive but not in regard to career development. While this might be indicative of a 'Hai Dai' situation, it would be somewhat harsh to view these ultimately successful students as failures given that they have experienced career success; it is only the instrumental side of their credentials that has not 'paid off' rather than the full range of capacities. These remarks point towards the idea that mobility capital may be less strictly related to professional competencies and personal attributes, outside of the previously cited areas of foreign language fluency and knowledge of overseas customer bases, and are rather more of an imaginative resource than a pragmatic one. For example, as well as social conscientiousness, Norwegian mobility capital can be expressed in terms of self-confidence which is put to use in searching for work and in job interviews. Having acquired this self-confidence in Norway, the respondents did not feel defeated or dejected when they failed to get the job they wanted in China. Some nevertheless persevered and found a job after 3 to 6 months searching. In addition, they felt that their overseas experiences had opened-up more career possibilities.

> After my overseas study, I knew that besides being a teacher, climbing up to a leadership position and earning money, I can work for a Non-Governmental Organisation (NGO), to be a more useful person. After coming back to China, I paid special attention to job opportunities in NGOs. My first job was to work for a legal aid agency sponsored by the Dutch government and my overseas experience was one of the major reasons why my employer hired me. (Jack)

However, among the participants, although 10 are working in a field directly related to their academic majors, the others work in unrelated fields, limiting their capacity to employ the academic dimension of their mobility capital. For this reason, it is not necessarily the foreign study experience that confounds the utility of mobility capital but rather the state of the domestic job market. While this does not necessarily connote a 'loss' in career progression due to having studied abroad, and indeed it would be exceptional for all Chinese students obtaining a Norwegian Master's degree to have automatic career success on return to China, we do need to accept that there is an element of unpredictability in foreseeing a 'Hai Gui' situation. However, we do not find strong support for the idea of negative 'Hai Dai' outcomes, and from a more positive point of view, that seven of our respondents are now managers in their companies suggests that there are benefits in the mid to long term. And it was interesting that this success was attributed to studying abroad, specifically in having better interpersonal skills and English language fluency.

Discussion

In moving towards a conclusion, the findings of our study recognize that studying in Norway has proved to be a generally positive experience for our respondents and that the skills and capacities acquired during 2 to 3 years spent as Master's degree students in Oslo can be conceptualized as a manifestation of mobility capital. At a theoretical level, we have illustrated how this resource consists of a combination of different social, cultural and economic capitals, and that it is when a combination of these capitals is able to be mobilized through the finding of an appropriate labour market position that a career attains a dynamism not, presumably, available to others who lack this resource. And we have also noted a number of features specific to the experience of having studied in Norway that emphasize the utility of civic values alongside educational credentials that again provide potential advantage in a professional career in China, suggesting that a national or communal habitus matters as much as the institutional educational environment in this process.

The preceding accounts also make clear that 'Hai Gui' situations far outweigh the risk of becoming 'Hai Dai', and even when it was not possible to utilize one's Norwegian mobility capital, it did not mean that problems were being experienced in the labour market. This is because this resource can be defined both in terms of academic credentials obtained while abroad and a more amorphous range of attributes, including the freedom to think positively and constructively about the future. So while the capacity to operationalize the academic aspect of mobility capital is mediated by choice of career path and the range of career opportunities available to a graduate on return to China, there is transversal value in Norwegian mobility capital,

for example, in learning of new ways of thinking about everyday issues ranging from caring for the environment to finding a job.

Lest we seem too positive, we do need to bear in mind the limitations of our study. Our 17 respondents were mostly drawn from a quite specific cultural and economic milieu: self-financing postgraduate students from China who had previously studied at the University of Oslo. For this reason, we do not make any claims towards universality or being representative and would therefore stop short of making prescriptive recommendations regarding the suitability of studying in Norway for other overseas students. We can, however, suggest that future research on student migration engages with a broader range of participants in studying mobility capital in Norway or in relation to other destinations. And a more in-depth longitudinal approach would obviously yield potentially more robust outcomes. However, in specific regard to our own research context, we can offer the following ideas that we feel fellow researchers may wish to learn from.

First, despite an initial lack of familiarity with Norwegian culture, and the English language, we have shown that foreign students are able to psychologically and socioculturally adapt and to use this capacity to adapt in other contexts at a later point in the life course. Knowing this is an important sociological contribution to our understanding of student migration, which is not just about enhancing an individual's earning potential but also about collectively contributing to a country's civic life, for example, in an appreciation for the Norwegian culture of respecting the environment and creating mutual respect through trust. We would therefore argue that our study represents a good example of intercultural learning, a faculty that can change returnees' lives and attitudes for the better. But we can also argue that this commitment has yielded positive career outcomes, with several respondents choosing to work in jobs relating to caring for the environment or being social responsible, thus making a valuable contribution to Chinese society.

Second, being able to have clear aims in life and plans for the future was an attribute associated with studying in Norway, a finding that echoes work within the European tradition of Youth Studies (see, e.g., Leccardi, 2005). Not only were respondents able to appreciate the value of hard work, they could also see that in order to be able to use their talents in the labour market they had to think ahead and plan incrementally. In this sense, the 'pay-off' for studying abroad is not necessarily immediate but may take more time to emerge. This process can hence be associated with development in interpersonal skills beyond job hunting, confirming the finding of Norris and Gillespie (2008) that overseas study experiences may have more influence on participants' personal lives than on their careers, or their political and social views. Therefore, while it may have been the aim of the respondents to gain advantages in the job market, and at the same time learn more about another culture, in moving to Norway they may have got more than they originally bargained for.

Finally, our study also provides an illustration of student migration outside the narrow confines of the socio-economic elite, who predominate within intra-European circuits of tertiary education (Murphy-Lejeune, 2002). In this sense, we are illustrating that student migration can take place in education systems without reproducing existing structures of socio-economic privilege (see Bourdieu, 1996). This was possible due to relatively egalitarian access to postgraduate education in Norway: that our respondents did not have to pay tuition fees made Oslo an attractive destination

for those from middle-income backgrounds. And significantly, we have been able to show how these students have repaid this de facto investment in their educational development by a foreign country, providing a justification for this policy. Studying abroad should therefore not just be a luxury, particularly when it represents a means of generating and spreading civic-mindedness in addition to career success. And even though many of our respondents had to make recourse to part-time working in order to support themselves, this ultimately provided another opportunity to learn how to acclimatize to the job market and empathize with fellow employees.

Funding Information

David Cairns was financially supported by the Portuguese Foundation for Science and Technology (FCT), as part of the project, 'International Student Mobility: A Socio-Demographic Perspective' under Grant number SFRH/BPD/103320/2014.

Notes

1. The origins of the term 'Hai Gui' have been attributed to Ren Hong, a young man from Guangzhou who returned to China with a degree from Yale in the USA (Wattanavitukul, 2002). The origins of 'Hai Dai' are less clear.
2. As a Chinese-based research project, our position will also be different to that of academics studying incoming youth migration to Norway, in that we concentrate upon return rather than in transit or settlement experiences. A further perspective that has been prominent in the Nordic countries is the study of young people as migrants or members of national and ethnic minorities whose motivations may include the desire to improve one's educational profile, including those at secondary level and in apprenticeships (Støren, 2011), as well as processes of entering and remaining within the labour market (Fangen and Paasche, 2013).
3. While not the focus of this study, we should also mention that not only is studying abroad popular for undergraduates and postgraduates but there is also large-scale internal student migration in China (Du, 2015; Han, 2009).
4. All names have been changed to protect the privacy of our respondents.

References

Anwar, Muhammad (1979) *The Myth of Return: Pakistanis in Britain*. London: Heinemann.

Balaz, Vladimír and Williams, Allan M. (2004) '"Been There, Done That": International Student Migration and Human Capital Transfers from the UK to Slovakia', *Population, Space and Place* 10(3): 217–37.

Bodycott, Peter (2009) 'Choosing a Higher Education Study Abroad Destination: What Mainland Chinese Parents and Students Rate as Important', *Journal of Research in International Education* 8(3): 349–73.

Bovenkerk, Frank (1974) *The Sociology of Return Migration: A Bibliographic Essay* (Publications of the Research Group for European Migration Problems, No. 20). The Hague, Netherlands : Martinus Nijhoff Publishers.

Bourdieu, Pierre (1984) *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste.* Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

_____ (1986) 'The Forms of Capital', in John G. Richardson (ed.) *Handbook of Theory and Research for the Sociology of Education*, pp. 241–58. New York: Greenwood Press.

_____ (1996) *The State Nobility. Elite Schools in the Field of Power*. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Brooks, Rachel and Waters, Johanna L. (2011) *Student Mobilities, Migration and the Internationalization of Higher Education*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.

Cairns, David (2014) *Youth Transitions, International Student Mobility and Spatial Reflexivity: Being Mobile?* Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.

Cairns, David and Growiec, Katarzyna (2011) 'Learning Insularity: Social Learning, Social Capital and Staying at Home among European Youth', in Zvi Beckerman and Thomas Geisen (eds) *Migration, Minorities, and Learning—Understanding Cultural and Social Differences in Education*, pp. 729–42. New York: Springer.

Cassarino, Jean-Pierre (2008) 'Conditions of Modern Return Migrants—Editorial Introduction', *International Journal on Multicultural Societies* 10(2): 95–105.

Crossman, Johanna Elisabeth and Clarke, Marilyn (2010) 'International Experience and Graduate Employability: Stakeholder Perceptions on the Connection', *Higher Education* 59(5): 599–613.

Cuzzocrea, Valentina and Mandich, Giuliana (2015) 'Students' Narratives of the Future: Imagined Mobilities as forms of Youth Agency?', *Journal of Youth Studies* 19(4): 552–67.

Du, Huimin (2015) 'Place Attachment and Belonging among Educated Young Migrants and Returnees: The Case of Chaohu, China', *Population, Space and Place*. doi:10.1002/psp.1967

EOL (2011) *Report of Overseas Study*, URL (consulted May, 2016): http://liuxue.eol.cn/html/lx/Special/2011/lxfx/index.shtml

European Commission (2014) *Erasmus + Inclusion and Diversity Strategy—In the Field of Youth*. Brussels: European Commission.

Fangen, Katrine and Paasche, Erlend (2013) 'Young Adults of Ethnic Minority Background on the Norwegian Labour Market: The Interactional Co-construction of Exclusion by Employers and Customers', *Ethnicities* 13(5): 607–24.

Feyen, Benjamin and Krzaklewska, Ewa (eds) (2013) *The Erasmus Phenomenon—Symbol of a New European Generation*. Frankfurt: Peter Lang.

Furlong, Andy and Cartmel, Fred (1997) *Young People and Social Change: Individualisation and Risk in Late Modernity*. Buckingham: Open University Press.

Guth, Jessica and Gill, Bryony (2008) 'Motivations in East-West Doctoral Mobility: Revisiting the Question of Brain Drain', *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies 34*(5): 825–41.

Halve, Helene and Bynner, John (eds) (2007) *Youth and Social Capital*. London: Tufnell Press.

Han, Xiao-Jie (2009) 'Job-Hunting Prospects of People Who Study Abroad at their Own Expense', *Journal of Huaihai Institute of Technology* (Social Science Edition) *7*(4): 130–32.

Hao, Jie and Welsh, Anthony R. (2013) 'Hai Gui and Hai Dai: The Job-seeking Experiences of High-skilled Returnees to China', in Ka-Ho Mok and Ku Ming You, (eds) *Internationalization of Higher Education in East Asia: Trends of Student Mobility and Impact on Education Governance*, pp. 90–114. London: Routledge.

King, Russell, Findlay, Alan and Ahrens, Jill (2010) *International Student Mobility Literature Review.* Sussex: University of Sussex/HEFCE.

Kurdziel, Josepha P. and Libarkin, Julie C. (2002) 'Research Methodologies in Science Education: Undergraduate Research Mentoring, Teacher Workshops, and K-12 Outreach Activities', *Journal of Geoscience Education* 50(5): 602–09.

Jöns, Heike (2011) 'Transnational Academic Mobility and Gender', *Globalisation, Societies and Education* 9(2): 183–209.

Leccardi, Carmen (2005) 'Facing Uncertainty: Temporality and Biographies in the New Century', *Young* 13(2): 123–46.

Ley, David and Kobayashi, Audrey (2005) 'Back to Hong Kong: Return Migration or Transnational Sojourn?', *Global Networks* 5(2): 111–27.

Louie, Kam (2006) 'Returnee Scholars: Ouyang Yu, the Displaced Poet and the Sea Turtle', *New Zealand Journal of Asian Studies* 8(1): 1–16.

McBurnie, Grant and Ziguras, Christopher (2001) 'The Regulation of Transnational Higher Education in Southeast Asia: Case Studies of Hong Kong, Malaysia and Australia', *Higher Education* 41(1): 85–105.

MoE (2016) Introduction to 'Blue Print of Employment of Overseas Returnees 2015', URL (consulted May, 2016): https://www.moe.edu.cn/jyb_xwfb/xw_fbh/moe_2069/xwfbh_2016n/xwfb_160325_01/160325_sfcl01/201603/t20160325_235214.html

Murphy-Lejeune, Elizabeth (2002) *Student Mobility and Narrative in Europe. The New Strangers*. London: Routledge.

Norris, Emily Mohajeri and Gillespie, Joan (2008) 'How Study Abroad Shapes Global Careers Evidence from the United States', *Journal of Studies in International Education* 13(3): 382–97.

O'Connor, Pat (2005) 'Local Embeddedness in a Global World: Young People's Accounts', *Young* 13(1): 9–26.

Putnam, Robert D. (2000) *Bowling Alone: The Collapse and Revival of American Community.* New York: Simon and Schuster.

Støren, Liv Anne (2011) 'Key Factors Behind Labour Market Marginalization of Young Immigrants: Limited Access to Apprenticeships, "State Dependence" or Low Qualifications?', *Young* 19(2): 129–58.

UNESCO (2016) *Global Flow of Tertiary Students*, URL (consulted May, 2016): http://www.uis.unesco.org/Education/Pages/international-student-flow-viz.aspx

Waters, Johanna L. (2005) 'Transnational Family Strategies and Education in the Contemporary Chinese Diaspora', *Global Networks* 5(4): 359–77.

Waters, Johanna L. (2006) 'Geographies of Cultural Capital: Education, International Migration and Family Strategies between Hong Kong and Canada', *Transactions of the Institute of British Geographers* 31(2): 179–92.

Wattanavitukul, Piset (2002, April) 'Hai Gui: The Sea Turtles Come Marching Home', *Asia Pacific Management Forum*, URL (consulted May, 2016): http://www.apmforum.com/columns/china19.htm

Yoon, Kyong (2014) 'Transnational Youth Mobility in the Neoliberal Economy of Experience', *Journal of Youth Studies* 17(8): 1014–28.

Authors' Bio-sketch

Aihua Hu is a postdoctoral research fellow in the Department of Education Studies at Hong Kong Baptist University. Her research interests include teacher education and teacher development, curriculum, language education, teaching and learning, and inclusive education. An important aspect of her work has been how concurrent curricula, namely, formal curriculum, extra-curriculum and hidden curriculum have shaped and influenced the education of future teachers in China.

David Cairns is a senior researcher at the Centre for Research and Studies in Sociology, ISCTE-University of Lisbon. His main research interests are in youth, mobility, employment, education and political participation. Publications include five books on youth-related themes and articles in journals including *Young*, *Journal of Youth Studies*, *International Migration* and *British Journal of Sociology of Education*.